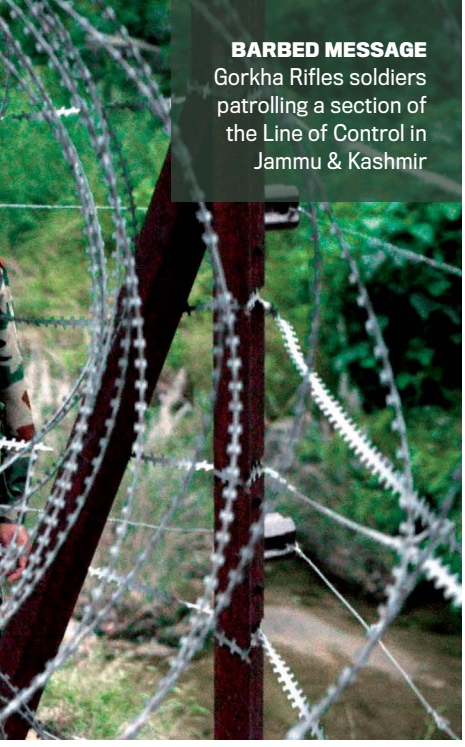


BARBED MESSAGE
Gorkha Rifles soldiers patrolling a section of the Line of Control in Jammu & Kashmir

TODAY from Kathmandu.

With no Nepali Gorkhas joining the Indian army in four years, the number of soldiers in the Gorkha Regiments is steadily falling and could impact their operational effectiveness. If the status quo continues, in the next 10 years, there will be no Nepali in the army, robbing it of high-quality soldiers. To address the problem, army chief Gen. Manoj Pande had in 2022 stated that the vacancies allotted to Nepali Gorkhas would be redistributed to others "for the time being". Likewise, it is known that some Indian Kumaoni and Garhwali youths were recruited into Gorkha regiments and there is a lookout for youths from the hills 'with similar traits' to the Gorkhas.

Not just the loss of exceptional fighting men, experts believe that the Nepalis not joining the Indian army is a massive loss to India's strategic reach in the Himalayan nation, as they are our "eyes and ears" there. The idea that Nepali youth might be drawn into China's ambit is the main concern.

THE CHINA FACTOR

Nepal is strategically located as a buffer state between India and China, and Beijing has in the past decade been increasing its footprint there. China has invested over $188 million in Nepal, mostly in energy and infrastructure projects, making it the largest source of foreign direct investment. In 2016, Nepali leaders declared China an "all-weather friend" and signed on to its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) the following year, when the Nepali army also held a joint military exercise with the PLA. In 2018, Beijing pledged Nepalese Rs 250 crore (RMB 150 million; Rs 157 crore) for the Nepalese army. Though in recent months, Nepal authorities have vowed to stop youths fighting in the Russian army in Ukraine, some believe it's a precursor to their being recruited by the Chinese.

"By not getting Nepalis, a vacuum is being created that any nation like China would like to occupy. China has been eyeing such an opportunity," says Lt Gen. Shokin Chauhan (retd), a former officer in a Gorkha regiment. He adds that though the PLA does not currently have the mechanism to recruit foreign soldiers, it is possible that China might create a border security guards unit with Gorkha soldiers.

TALE OF AN IMPASSE

- **Integral to the Indian army, around 32,000 Gorkhas (39 battalions) are currently part of seven Gorkha regiments, and 60 per cent are from Nepal**
- **The pay/ pension they receive from India is crucial for Nepal's economy**
- **But the pandemic and Nepal's objection to the Agnipath scheme for enlisting soldiers have stalled recruitment for four years**
- **Nepal says the scheme violates the 1947 agreement that provides for Nepali citizens to serve in the Indian army**
- **The depleting ranks of Nepali Gorkhas is a blow to the army and to India's strategic reach in Nepal**
- **With Nepali youths fighting for Russia in Ukraine, some fear they are ripe for recruitment by China**

However, experts believe that Gorkhas will never want to join the PLA and that, due to tradition and religious reasons, the Indian army would always be their first preference. But with little opportunity for employment, they might be pushed into that direction. Indeed, there are indications that Beijing is trying to encourage that subtly.

In the summer of 2020, when the Indian military and the PLA started their face-off in eastern Ladakh, Beijing funded a Nepali think-tank—China Study Centre—to conduct a detailed study on Nepalis being recruited in the Gorkha regiments of the Indian army. It not only aimed to find out the reasons behind Gorkhas joining the Indian army, but also the socioeconomic impact on the areas from where such recruitment is made and their interest in joining armed forces of foreign countries. Indian intelligence agencies are also aware of the increased activities of Chinese-funded thinktanks along the India-Nepal border. The continued presence of Nepali Gorkhas in the Indian Army is thus vital to counter the growing Chinese presence in Nepal.

Maj. Gen. Binoj Basnyat (retd), a former officer with the Nepali army and a strategist, believes that till both Nepal and India resolve the differences over Agnipath, Nepali youth should still be allowed to join the Indian army under some mechanism. "If they can join the Russian army for a few bucks, then why can't they join the Indian army? Otherwise, other nations will lure unemployed youth," he argues.

A resumption of Nepali Gorkhas joining the Indian army is in the security, strategic and economic interests of India and Nepal. It's up to the two governments to repair this damaging rupture and break the deadlock. ■